First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
All Saints Day
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ Sacred Remembrance
1 November 2026



Celebration by John August Swanson, 1997

Preaching: ML
Worship Leading: Pastors

Choir's Presentation
Strips of paper in programs for prayers, mementos laid on Communion Table
Sound Techs: We will need one solo mic for the oratorio.

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura and Michael center chancel]

Welcome **LVF**

Good morning and welcome to First Congregational Church of Los Angeles.

- Today, we observe All Saints Day, a sacred service of memory and hope; a time for honoring, remembering, and grieving all who have gone before us.
- During our time of Prayer and Silence, we will be invited to place an item of remembrance on the table along with our prayers, and light a candle as we remember individually, and together.

- And then, our Cathedral Choir will offer the gift of music through their program, Becoming Earth.

As we begin, let us now, join our voices for these Words of Gathering…

Words of Gathering **ML & LVF**

ML: Like potter's clay on spinning wheel,
grasped by strong hands that push and pull,
our lives take shape in height and breadth,
in form and grace most wonderful.

LVF: Our vision is shaped by hands of love,
and what we know is what we see.
We look at life as through a lens.
The eyes of love see differently.

ML: As hatred blooms around the world,
as evil reigns and has its way,
the eyes of love are filled with hope.
Hate cannot last, love comes to stay.

LVF: So, come now, friends,
in this time, share in the words and the music.
Let our lives be brought into being by love,
as we join together to change our beloved earth.

Both: ***With the music of heaven and the chorus of the ancestors,***
we lift our hearts in gratitude
for life and for love and for this day! [adapt/gv]

LVF: ***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.***

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn of Gathering** ***For All the Saints SINE NOMINE

For all the saints, who from their labors rest,
Who in the world their faith in God confessed,
Your name, oh Jesus, be forever blessed:
Alleluia, Alleluia!

You were the stranger in the dark of night
With whom they strove to find their one true light,
To whom you ever give God's blessing ever bright:
Alleluia, Alleluia!

There are the ones who gave us Love Divine,

Always in service did their wills incline,
Forgetting self, they did with glory shine:
Alleluia, Alleluia!

And there will dawn a yet more glorious day
The saints with laughter sing and dance and play,
The Christ of all rejoices in the way:
Alleluia, Alleluia!

With earth restored, with this our fragile star
In gladness home from pilgrimage afar
We find in God a joy that none can mar:
Alleluia, Alleluia!
-lyrics adapted by J. Cotter

[Laura center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness** **LVF**
Let us pray together:
On this day, Holy One,
for all the saints who went before us,
who have spoken to our hearts and touched us with your fire,
We give thanks, O God.

For all the saints who live beside us,
whose weaknesses and strengths are woven with our own,
We give thanks, O God.

For all the saints who live beyond us,
who challenge us to change the world with them,
We give thanks, O God. -- Janet Morley, England

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us. Amen and Amen.

***Introit** When the Earth Stands Still Don MacDonald
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*
So stay with me, held in my arms like branches of a tree–they'll shelter you for many years, when the Earth stands still.

[Michael center chancel]

***The Lord's Prayer** **ML**
Let us now share these words for the Lord's Prayer, adapted from the New Zealand Book of Prayer…
Eternal Spirit

Life Giver, Pain Bearer, Love-Maker;
Source of all that is and that shall be;
Father and Mother of us all;
Loving God, in whom is heaven:
The hallowing of your name
echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed
By all peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done
By all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom
Sustain our hope and come on earth.

With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure, spare us.
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.

For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,
now and forever. Amen.

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **LVF**
On each occasion when we glimpse them:
that turn of a head, that smile,
the way they walked, their sense of humor,
each time we feel the empty space in our heart.

In time, through the window of our tears,
we see them and smile.
In time, we let go of the sorrow.
In time, beauty and music,
and remembered places bring solace, not pain.

In your time, God of all time,
may what we have sown in pain, be reaped in joy.
[adapted/Iona Community]

On this All Saints Day, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Michael center chancel]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition ***from the Book of Genesis*** **ML**

Hear now this reading from the Book of Genesis, chapter 25…

These are the days and years of the life of Abraham: he was 175 years old when he was gathered to his ancestors, and having lived a full and abundant life, he breathed his last. His heirs Isaac and Ishmael buried him in the cave at Machpelah, in the field of Ephron ben-Zoar the Hittite, east of Mamre—the plot which Abraham had bought from the Hittites. Abraham was buried there with Sarah, his wife. After Abraham's death, God blessed Isaac, who had settled near the Well of the Living One Who Sees Me.

This is the memory of the people.
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph short transition LVF center chancel]

Prayers with the People **LVF**

Invitation to the Lighting of the Candles and the Prayers of Remembrance
As we spend these precious moments in silence, we invite you to take the pieces of paper in your programs and to write a name or names, and a word, a memory, or prayer of thanks and blessing for the lives of those you wish to remember and honor.

We also acknowledge this morning that some of our memories of those who have died may be painful and our emotions conflicted…we invite you to write these feelings as well, and the pieces of these memories - you would like to leave behind as you begin, and continue to walk, into new paths for your healing.

If no one is immediately present to you in your memory, perhaps you will remember those around the world who have died because of violence, because of prejudice, because of an impending famine, or because of wars in their homelands.

So, in this silence and remembering - with each exhale of our breath- may we let go.
In each inhale, may we breathe in the Love that holds us now and forever.

And then, ***As the music begins, you are invited to place items of remembrance on the table, your prayers in the gold bowls, and to light a candle as we honor, remember, and celebrate those we love on this All Saints Day.***

Silence

As the music begins, you are invited to place items of remembrance on the table, your prayers in the gold bowls, and to light a candle as we honor, remember, and celebrate those we love on this All Saints Day.

Prayer of Our Hearts
Holy One, we ask that in the mystery of your love,
you will take all that we have brought and bring
blessing and life from our remembrance,
as together we hold all that has been.

For all whose names we know,
for all those whose names are unknown,
and to each person here,
send your Spirit, O God, to make us whole,
to make us know deep within our being
that you have created us in your image,
and that you are our Mother and Father,
our sibling, our friend,
our Ever-present God,
forever and ever.
Amen and Amen.

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit]

Reflection ***Sacred Remembrance*** **ML**

[Christoph transition for choir]

Musical Gift ***Becoming Earth***

An Oratorio curated and conducted by Dr. Ianthe Marini and Dr. Fahad Siadat
Featuring Cathedral Choir, Laude, Soloists, and Dr. Christoph Bull (Piano and Organ)
In this oratorio, we honor the sacredness of each life as it passes through the cycle of Earth to Breath, to Earth again.

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Precious Lord, Take my Hand Thomas Dorsey, arr. Arnold Sevier
Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

A Poetic Recitation of Clare Harner's In Remembrance – Meg Russett

In Remembrance Music: Eleanor Daley, Text: Clare Harner
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

I Will Be Earth Music: Gwyneth Walker, Text: May Swenson
Tiffany Ho and Kion Heidari, *Soloists,* Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano,*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

More Than Enough Music: Susan LaBarr, Text: Wendell Berry
Frank Hobbs, *Soloist,* Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

A Reading from Robin Wall Kimmerer's Braiding Sweetgrass – Dr. Jay Prewitt Cruz

Last Will Music and Text by Aria Gittelson
Laude, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

As One Sky Music: Paul John Rudoi, Text: Kabir
Anna Caplan, *Soloist,* Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

I Came to this Life in Joy Music and Text by Lauren Spavelko
Molly Pease, *Soloist,* Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organ,* Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

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[Christoph transition Laura center]

Invitation to Generosity **LVF**

Offertory- This will be Christoph- bring the mood into an uplifting place.

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Michael center chancel toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer** **ML**

In ways known and unknown
you, Holy One, have spoken
to each of us this day.
We pray that through the gifts of this time,
we may once again be transformed into your likeness.

Remembering the saints that surround us,
help us to follow in their footsteps
as peacemakers in our homes,
in our schools, our jobs,
our government,
and our world.

May the spirit of love and gratitude
and the gifts we have shared,
empower us to enhance and enrich
the beauty of life lived in your goodness,
and grace. [Duck/Tirabassi]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen!

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church **ML & LVF**

-Invitation to Coffee Hour

-Food@First team serving today. Giving thanks for them and for our Gardens Team that harvested this am.

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Words of Blessing **ML & LVF**

LVF: For those
who walked with us,
this is a prayer.

ML: For those
who have gone ahead,
this is a blessing.

LVF: For those

who touched and tended us,
who lingered with us
while they lived,
this is a thanksgiving.

ML: For those
who journey still with us
in the shadows of awareness,
in the crevices of memory,
in the landscape of our dreams,
this is a benediction.

Both: ***Bless us, God,***
with saints to tell us stories,
with angels to surprise us,
and friends along the way.
Amen and Amen.

[Michael motion for congregation to stand]

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn for the Journey** ***We Sing for All the Unsung Saints ELLACOMBE

We sing for all the unsung saints, that countless, nameless throng,
Who kept the faith and passed it on, with hope steadfast and strong.
Through all the daily griefs and joys no chronicles record,
Forgetful of their lack of fame, but mindful of our God.

Though uninscribed with date or place, with title, rank, or name,
As living stones their stories join to form a hallowed frame.
Around their mystery in their midst: the one once sanctified,
The Love that wrested life from death, the love of the Divine.

So we take heart from unknown saints bereft of earthly fame,
Those faithful ones who have received a more enduring name.
For they reveal true blessing comes when our pride efface
And offer back our lives to be the vessels of God's grace.

-lyrics by Carl P. Daw, Jr., 1996

No Choral Response

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music- Dr. Ianthe Marini

Becoming Earth is an oratorio specifically curated for our congregation, choir, cathedral, and continued journey with the Celtic theological notion that our sacred souls emanate from and become part of the sacred earth. From the matter of the universe we come, and into the matter we ultimately go: the spirit of the earth, sea, and sky nourish us as we will then nourish others in our passage back to it.

The oratorio begins with Thomas Dorsey's invocation for beloved community with and through the Divine — *take my hand*, he pleas, through the tragedy of losing his wife and child in childbirth: this song and poem his immediate response to that event, we connect with one another and remember that it is through community that we take hands together to heal. From there, we sing Eleanor Daley's illustrative setting of the Clare Harner poem *In Remembrance—"do not stand at my grave and weep…for I am the sunlight, the winds that blow, the glint on snow, the birds in circled flight, the soft stars at night."* From there, the 20th century setting of Swenson's poetry with Walker's music stating that "*I will be earth, you the flower, I the root, you the rain: you and I the sea*."

From this evocation of earth and soul comes the poetry of Wendell Berry, environmental activist and spirit guide to all we do here at First Church, stating that here on earth we have *more than enough.* We are reminded of the early teachings of Celtic monk Pelagius, deemed a heretic by the Imperial Church of Rome, for insisting that there are those on earth who have enough, those who do not have enough, and those who have more than enough: the reason that some do not have enough is from the hoarding of those with more than enough. A 4th century idea that rings true still, as we sing Susan LaBarr's illustrative music as poetic motion—"*enough. And more than enough."*

From there, we hear the words of Indigenous author Robin Wall Kimmerer whose book *Braiding Sweetgrass* has served as our spiritual companion this Fall. In her words she encourages us to take only what we need, and to then use the rest in the feeding of others—earth, animal, human. Leading us into the music and poetry of dear friend and former sound technician at the Cathedral, Aria Gittelson, whose work *Last Will* journeys us through that which we know to be true—our bodies and spirits are here to help nourish one another. "*Give all the things that people may need to the people that need 'em. Be it money or clothes or whatever, I mean it, just pay 'em and feed 'em. Whatever they want, whatever they want, take it straight off my body while they're putting' me under. After some time, I bet I'll bloom. I bet you'll join me I bet you'll bloom too. I bet you'll feed me and I'll feed you. I bet we'll bloom."*

From there, Paul John Rudoi's ecstatic fantasia setting the poetry of Kabir, 15th century mystic and poet whose works heavily influenced the Hindi, Sufi, and Sikh traditions. In it, we express

our intermingling in both the conscious and the unconscious space and time continuum, that we wake as "*the moon and sky are within us, as is the sun, the inward and the outward are become as one sky, the Infinite and the finite are united."* It is through this *swing* that we realize all is love, as it swells forth. And finally, we end our journey in an exclamatory song of praise by another friend to First Church, Lauren Spavelko, whose music and text harken back to Appalachian hymn singing roots — a provocative and euphoric exclamation that *"I came to this life in joy and at the end, in joy, I'll go, and 'tween the two I'll sing my story.I came to this life in joy, and at the end, in joy, I go. Something new is waiting for me. Like a wave that turns to foam, whatever shape the water takes it always was the sea—I'll be there with you in the air when you remember me."*